

Preston Carey Leslie

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Dear Carrie Gundermann and Members of the Selection Committee,

I am writing to express my enthusiastic interest in the Digital & Data Services Supervisor position at Oregon Metro. As an Implementation Architect and systems modeler holding a Master of Science in Quantitative Methods and Modeling from Baruch College, my professional identity centers on serving as a strategic liaison who bridges the gaps between data logic, frontline workflows, and organizational strategy. I am currently executing a permanent, self-funded relocation to the Portland metro area. Driven by an affinity for the Pacific Northwest's unique landscape and a desire to align my technical tools with progressive, triple-bottom-line public service, I am fully prepared to anchor my long-term career within Oregon Metro's digital evolution.

Oregon Metro's mandate to solve organizational friction through modern digital service frameworks, agile delivery, and an AI-augmented data posture matches my precise operational baseline. I function as a "Bone-Setter" for internal systems, meaning I actively scope for ambiguous problems, optimize relational architectures, and pass clean specifications to core engineers. Below, I have provided direct responses to your evaluative prompts to demonstrate how my technical fluency and leadership style map directly to your roadmap.

Part 1: Targeted Leadership Narrative – The Anomaly Optimization Initiative

The Situation & My Role

During my graduate curriculum at the Zicklin School of Business, I served as the informal Technical Lead and statistical anchor for a multidisciplinary analytics initiative tasked with building a reproducible, multi-layer epidemiological data engine. The objective was to evaluate the predictive power of neighborhood-level socioeconomic attributes against localized HIV case counts.

Because I was the only practitioner on the team who had advanced beyond foundational managerial statistics into high-level programmatic modeling, my leadership extended far beyond raw code execution. I acted as the team's educational resource, regularly translating dense, abstract statistical concepts, cross-validating homework and test preparations, and ensuring the entire group maintained complete conceptual alignment throughout our weekly sprint cycles.

The Decision

The raw datasets arrived across nine disconnected sheets encompassing 186 raw records filled with invalid negative formatting flags (-1, -5, -8, -9) used for privacy suppression. I engineered a custom Python processing script to sweep the sheets, isolate the suppression flags, and drop sparse demographic variables to conform the final analytical matrix to 141 high-fidelity ZIP code zones.

Prior to finalizing our approach, our team engineered an exploratory Multiple Linear Regression (MLR) pipeline backed by Leave-One-Out Cross-Validation (LOOCV). To distribute the workload effectively, I delegated the baseline MLR, LOOCV, and K-Means clustering execution to my teammates, as these

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methodologies aligned closely with our core coursework, while I served as the technical reviewer for their code. The resulting cross-validation loop unmasked a distinct 1.96x generalization gap (In-Sample Training MSE of 2,585 vs. Out-of-Sample LOOCV MSE of 5,062), exposing severe covariance and systemic multicollinearity across our demographic predictors.

Based on this diagnostic data, I directed our strategic pivot away from the ordinary linear framework. While maintaining oversight as the team's code reviewer, I focused my personal programming execution on building our complex data-cleaning pipelines and independently engineering the offset Poisson generalized linear model (GLM) with a log-link function. I communicated the structural mechanics of this advanced architecture to the team so our designated Writing Lead could accurately capture our methodology in the final brief. When initial model sweeps unmasked a massive outlier footprint at ZIP code 11370, my root-cause analysis traced the distortion to the Rikers Island correctional facility. Rather than lazily deleting this critical data point to deliver a visually clean baseline, I engineered an explicit categorical dummy variable to isolate the facility's unique operational trend line without polluting our broader regional baseline.

The Result

This decision resulted in complete mathematical stability. Incorporating the institutional control variable caused the model's baseline Deviance metric to plummet from a highly unstable 27,695 down to a tight 3,644 in the sensitivity iteration. The finalized engine achieved a statistically robust McFadden's Pseudo R-squared of 0.3922, confirming an elite fit for real-world categorical count modeling.

Ultimately, this model empirically proved that localized income inequality (the Gini coefficient) serves as a far more potent predictor of systemic health burden than absolute poverty markers alone when median household income is held fully constant. The project received top-tier marks and functions as a live data asset on my public portfolio.

Part 2: Modern AI Posture & The AI-Augmented Lifecycle

How I Use AI Tools Today

I do not treat AI as a future hypothetical or a tool for generating superficial text. I operate as a genuinely AI-capable technical leader who has spent my entire graduate tenure executing data workflows within an embedded, AI-augmented paradigm. I routinely leverage advanced language models as technical engineering sparring partners to rapid-prototype custom Python preprocessing modules, optimize dense SQL and dbt transformation layers, cross-validate complex relational database schemas, and debug environment configuration bottlenecks across my local Git and Quarto deployment architectures.

This technical strategy is precisely how I maintain a fluent, highly practical operational literacy boundary. I possess the technical depth required to read codebases, manipulate JSON data buses, and audit database

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schemas to direct practitioners effectively, allowing me to speak the native language of core engineers and BI developers without getting bogged down in individual contributor production debt.

Leading the Challenge Differently Today with AI

Because our epidemiological capstone initiative explicitly utilized AI to accelerate our initial Python cleaning sweeps and assist in the foundational code execution of our Poisson regression model, I have already stress-tested this tool in a high-stakes team setting. If I were directing that same challenge today within Oregon Metro's modern digital service framework, my pivot would not be the introduction of AI, but the elevation of the team's creative potential and capacity from Day One:

- **Systematizing the Intake Pipeline:** In our original workflow, I partnered with AI from day one to write our data exploration and cleaning scripts, allowing me to focus my cognitive energy on absorbing the context of the raw data and mapping out our analytical path. Directing this project today within a digital services framework, I would formalize this AI-assisted code-writing strategy right from the project charter phase. By standardizing these collaborative development workflows across the entire multidisciplinary team, we would instantly accelerate the initial cleaning and schema validation of the 186 raw records, compressing what used to take weeks into a highly efficient, unified lifecycle.
- **Maximizing Frontline Discovery Bandwidth:** By strategically offloading routine syntax loops and initial error troubleshooting to collaborative prompting setups, the team gains an expanded operational boundary to execute projects. However, this is never an absolute untethering from foundational engineering skills; I expect every practitioner on a multidisciplinary team to maintain a sharp command of traditional text editors and the capability to play within the code and build basic items entirely independent of AI. This balanced approach allows us to aggressively redirect our collective cognitive focus toward human-centered discovery and stakeholder engagement, without sacrificing the core technical literacy required to step in and manually correct a pipeline if an automated utility fails.
- **Focusing on Outcomes via Strategic Maneuverability:** I do not view technical delivery as a blind, straight-line advance, especially given rising public outcries demanding accountability and the high probability of imminent regulatory interventions reining in unmanaged models. A team completely unleashed into an automated dependency risks catastrophic operational failure if shifting political or compliance environments suddenly cut off access to their tools. Instead, I govern technical delivery as a series of calculated maneuvers. We step forward to capitalize on cutting-edge automation when stable, but maintaining the hardcoded organizational muscle

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memory to pivot backward, route around architectural collapses, and rely entirely on traditional, manual relational database and analytical text foundations. This strategic flexibility protects public infrastructure from institutional vulnerability while keeping our focus permanently fixed on sustainable outcomes.

Part 3: Technical Fluency & Enterprise Data Architecture

My practical data fluency is thoroughly demonstrated in the end-to-end cloud and relational architecture I engineered for the Complaints & Inspections Project . This production-level dataset showcases my ability to direct a technical team across the entire modern data lifecycle, from serverless ingestion to shared dimensional modeling:

- **Cloud Run Ingestion & Schema Mutation Handling:** I engineered automated Python-based extraction services deployed on Google Cloud Run to systematically ingest high-volume records from the Socrata API. To ensure complete pipeline resilience, the scripts dynamically manage continuous loading by executing a live `COUNT(*)` query against existing BigQuery tables to calculate the starting offset for the next API chunk. Furthermore, I authored self-healing type-normalization logic that formats empty strings to `None` for database integrity, forces zip code columns to strings to preserve leading zeros, and automatically updates the target BigQuery schemas at runtime if the source API introduces new keys.
- **Staging & Heavy Regex Cleansing (dbt):** Within our dbt models (`stg_cafeteria_inspections`, `stg_nyc_311_doedohmh`), I implemented strict data governance filters. I developed robust regular expression schemas (`REGEXP_REPLACE` and `TRIM`) to eliminate whitespace debt and normalize disparate multi-agency strings, such as mapping volatile borough identifiers into conformed categorical keys to ensure clean joins downstream. To protect fact table integrity, I leveraged window functions (`QUALIFY ROW_NUMBER()`) to deduplicate redundant upstream entries.
- **Conformed Surrogate Keys & Star Schema Marts:** Using `dbt_utils.generate_surrogate_key`, I established cryptographic hash keys to define clear dimensions and fact boundaries across our datasets (`dim_problem`, `dim_school`, `dim_violation`). Crucially, I architected unified, shared dimensions, such as `dim_shared_date` via cross-mart `UNION DISTINCT` date arrays and `dim_shared_geography` merging spatial records. These conformed shared tables successfully united distinct public-sector datasets into integrated fact layers (`fact_service_request`, `fact_cafeteria_inspection`), turning fragmented data into a scalable, self-service business intelligence platform.

Cultivating the "Service Leader" Attribute & De Facto Operations Command

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My readiness to guide Oregon Metro's multidisciplinary digital team is anchored by a 14-year foundation in cross-functional operations management, including my tenure as a Senior Program and Account Lead at Del Monsoon, where I served as the primary point of accountability for end-to-end delivery, managing complex dependencies while dynamically scaling project teams from a lean two-person nucleus up to 100+ contingent personnel under rigid schedules.

This capacity to manage complex stakeholder networks is validated by my five years within the high-stakes healthcare ecosystem at Callen-Lorde Community Health Center during an enterprise-wide, 18,000-patient Epic EHR platform migration. Operating as the de facto leader for our Behavioral Health Patient Care Associates, I established a modern, supportive management framework focused on enablement rather than micromanagement. I engineered, documented, and delivered operational toolkits to onboarding personnel, giving my team autonomous resources to scale their efficiency without forcing rigid compliance. Because I earned deep horizontal credibility across departments, my peers routinely leveraged my voice as an escalation tool, asking me to directly interface with the Patient Administrations Supervisor and Behavioral Health Operations to advocate for systemic fixes.

My operational impact was so pronounced that during the final six months of my tenure, clinical providers and staff therapists repeatedly confided that they assumed I was a formal member of the BH Operations team. Because formal operational channels routinely suffered from bureaucratic latency, taking days or weeks to respond to frontline technical needs, clinical staff actively chose to bypass standard institutional queues to bring their high-priority operational bottlenecks directly to my desk first. I specialized in rapidly diagnosing these systemic friction points, deploying immediate workarounds, and unblocking providers so they could return safely to care delivery.

I am a service leader who listens before building, earning credibility with internal customers by thoroughly understanding their operational pain points before reaching for a technology solution. I demonstrated this early in my career by independently designing and successfully pitching an extensive operational framework connecting facility resource tracking to environmental sustainability metrics directly to our Chief Operating Officer and subsequent Chief Executive Officer.

I am eager to apply this exact blend of quantitative data fluency, practical product thinking, and human-centered situational leadership to Oregon Metro's IT and Records Management infrastructure. Thank you for your time, consideration, and leadership.

Best regards,

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